ML Application Review Template

Nov 11, 2026 · @David Kerr Kelly

Purpose

An ML Application is one institution's use of an off-the-shelf estimator. It stays inside SR 26-2 model risk scope and is reviewed through the same workflow as a model, ending in the same signed report to the MRC.

- **The owner** writes the brief, records each fit as a train, and answers the 12 ML review questions.
- **The reviewer** must be someone other than the owner. They give a verdict on each answer, agree each stage, and sign off.
- **The MRC** receives the report and decides the risk rating.

There are two differences from a model. An ML Application has no versions: the record of change is its sequence of trains, each holding the evidence that fit produced. And the institution decides through an MRC-ratified **ML review policy** which items a review must contain.

How the review runs

The seven stages are the same as a model's. Only the third stage's name changes, and the ML review policy adds a gate before the review can finish.

#	Stage	What is agreed for an ML Application
1	Preliminary documents	The pack: the ML Application Document, the latest train and its predecessors, testing and monitoring evidence
2	Assumptions	The assumptions register, e.g. that the training population is still representative
3	The ML review questions	A verdict on each of the 12 answers
4	Model weaknesses	The weaknesses register, together with the latest train's **qualifications**
5	Limitations of use	The limitations register, and the train's intended and excluded uses

#	Stage	What is agreed for an ML Application
6	Monitoring approach	The monitoring narrative and the monitoring readings
7	Remediation	What is outstanding, who owns it, by when

- **The policy gate.** Completing the review, and asking the MRC for a risk rating, are both refused while any item the division's policy marks mandatory is blank. The refusal names what is missing.
- **Nothing blocks recording.** A train or an answer can always be saved incomplete. Only finishing is gated.
- **The other rules are a model's.** An agreed stage can be reopened, every stage has a record of challenge that can't be edited, and sign-off is blocked while a stage is unagreed or a challenge is open.
- **Retraining.** A new fit is a new train, never an edit. A material retrain is the ML equivalent of a model's new version and should start a review with the New version trigger.

The template, section by section

The report has the same seven parts as a model review. What changes is the ML-specific content in each.

Part	Section	What it contains for an ML Application	Filled by
A	Identification	Record ID and name; **estimator and version, and why this estimator**; use case; **the train under review** (its ID and date) and how many trains came before it; owner, reviewer, trigger, scope; tier, materiality, complexity; current risk rating; last review	Owner, platform
B	Documents reviewed	The ML Application Document as issued for the review; the train(s) read; testing, benchmark and monitoring evidence, each with its version or date	Owner, reviewer marks read

Part	Section	What it contains for an ML Application	Filled by
	Challenge in summary	Challenges raised, answered and open, by stage	Platform
	Policy conformance	Items the policy marks mandatory, and whether each is filled; the policy version in force	Platform
C	The ML review questions	For each of the 12: owner's status and rationale, reviewer's verdict and comment, the train section or register it rests on	Owner, then reviewer
D	Findings	The train's **qualifications** (fit on full dataset, short split rationale, hold-out over-used, not reproduced); assumptions; weaknesses; limitations of use; fairness assessments; evaluations; monitoring; remediation	Owner proposes, reviewer agrees
E	Reviewer's opinion	Fit for use / Fit with conditions / Not fit; the conditions as remediation items; recommended risk rating	Reviewer, at sign-off
F	Record and attestation	The full record of challenge, stage agreements, final commentary, who signed and when	Platform, reviewer

A "Qualified" train is not a rating. It means something has been recorded that the reviewer must address, and part D is where they say how.

The ML review questions and their evidence

There are 12: the same five common questions an AI System is asked, then seven specific to a fitted estimator. Institutions can reword, drop or add questions in Admin, and the policy says which are mandatory.

#	Topic	Question	Evidence the reviewer checks
1	Use Case	What decision or task does this support, and what is it explicitly not to be used for?	Use case field; train section A (intended and excluded uses); Limitations stage
2	Human Oversight	Who reviews what it produces, on what basis, and would they catch it being wrong?	The consuming Product's RACI; limitations' compensating controls
3	Bias and Fairness	Who could be disadvantaged by its output, and how would you know?	Fairness assessments register
4	Explainability	Can a particular output be explained to the person affected by it, and to a regulator?	Methodology; train section E (segment performance)
5	Drift and Monitoring	What would show that it has stopped working, and who is watching for it?	Monitoring stage; monitoring readings
6	Algorithm Choice	Why this estimator rather than a simpler or alternative one?	Estimator rationale; benchmark evaluations
7	Training Data	What was it trained on, over what period, and is that population still representative?	Train section B; data sources
8	Data Leakage	Could any feature encode information that would not be available at prediction time?	Train section C (split before preprocessing); full-dataset fit qualifications
9	Out-of-Sample Performance	How does it perform on data it was not trained on, and against which metric?	Train section E; hold-out use count
10	Benchmarking	How does it compare with a simple baseline a reviewer would recognise?	Evaluations register; benchmark tests

#	Topic	Question	Evidence the reviewer checks
11	Overfitting and Stability	How were hyperparameters selected, and how stable is performance across resamples and over time?	Train sections D and E; the sequence of trains
12	Weaknesses and Misinterpretation	Where does it fail, and how might its output be misread by a consumer?	Weaknesses and Limitations stages

Question 12 and the weaknesses stage are one judgement, as assumptions and question 6 are for a model. No question asks for overall risk or reproduction; the opinion (part E) gives the conclusion, and the "not reproduced" qualification covers reproduction.

How the review relates to the train and the ML Application Document

The model review's main problem does not arise here. The ML Application Document is generated from the record on request, so it always answers the same questions the review gives verdicts on.

- **The document is the owner's account.** It prints the record, the latest train and the review questions. The review should cite the copy issued for it (part B), because a document generated later will reflect later trains.
- **The train is the evidence.** Fields the training code captured are facts and read-only. The roughly seven owner-written text boxes (target definition, uses, missing-data and split rationale, segment reading) are the argument, and that is where the reviewer's challenge belongs.
- **Qualifications are computed, not chosen.** A Qualified train has a finding the reviewer must address in part D. A train with "No findings" has nothing flagged, which is not the same as a pass.
- **The policy sets the floor.** The review can always ask for more than the policy requires, but it cannot finish with less.
- **Stale process doc.** `docs/MLGov/ml_applications_process.md` still describes ten questions; the platform seeds 12 (five common, seven ML). Correct it when this template is adopted.

What exists today and what is still to build

An ML Application already goes through the seven stages, is gated by the policy, and gets a signed report. The report prints only the registers a model has, so the train and its qualifications never reach the MRC through it.

Part	Today	To build
A Identification	Record, owner, reviewer, trigger, sign-off	Estimator and version, the train under review, risk rating
B Documents reviewed	Scope text only	The issued ML Application Document and the trains read
Challenge in summary	Live on main	—
Policy conformance	Enforced as a gate; shown on screen	Print the mandatory items and the policy version
C The ML review questions	Both sides on one row, under "The ML review questions"	The train section or register each verdict rests on
D Findings	Assumptions, weaknesses, limitations, monitoring narrative, remediation	Qualifications, fairness assessments, evaluations
E Reviewer's opinion	Missing	Same as for a model: opinion, conditions, recommended rating
F Record and attestation	Live	—

Suggested order: part E once for all three record types, then qualifications and the train in A and D, then policy conformance.